



Executive answer

To become a benchmark edtech company, Semester needs to package its unified University Operating System into a **procurement-ready, student-loved, institution-safe platform**. The strategic priority is to prove that Semester is not only broad—it is more connected, governable, trustworthy, and measurable than point solutions across planning, learning, support, career, campus life, and operations.

The winning formula is:

One connected student experience
+ One governed institutional platform
+ One trust and compliance program
+ One measurable pilot model
+ One repeatable go-to-market engine

Edtech benchmark audit

Semester’s strongest differentiator is its unified model: one identity, Action Center, Search, Workspace, AI layer, data model, permission system, and institution console across the entire student journey. The main competitive risk is not lack of ideas; it is ensuring each capability is deep, trustworthy, and operationally mature rather than merely present.

Competitive dimension	Typical point solution	Semester benchmark standard	Current priority
Student planning	Course planner or registration helper	Path, requirements, scenarios, schedule, backups, advisor agenda, registration handoff	Make My Path and Registration Day Mode production-grade
LMS and learning	Course delivery or AI study assistant	Course workspace connecting learning, assignments, study assets, support, skills, and career evidence	Build source-grounded Study Studio and course-policy controls
Advising	Appointment and note tool	Student-controlled plan, agenda, scenarios, source context, follow-ups, safe shares	Refine advisor view and consent-based sharing
Campus services	Directory or portal links	Context-aware campus graph, verified resources, events, deadlines, and Action Center handoffs	Add content ownership, freshness, and resource governance
Career	Job board or resume tool	Course-to-skill-to-portfolio-to-opportunity pathway	Build verified skills and student-controlled career evidence

Competitive dimension	Typical point solution	Semester benchmark standard	Current priority
Community	Generic feed or chat	Verified organizations, events, mentors, groups, study matching, safe collaboration	Start with opt-in, moderated, contextual communities
AI	Generic chatbot	Source-aware, permission-aware, academic-integrity-aware intelligence	Build citations, policies, feedback, controls, evaluation
Institution operations	Separate admin systems	Tenant configuration, roles, integrations, content, audit, feature flags, aggregate insights	Harden console as a governed operating center
Data trust	Opaque imports	Source, freshness, confidence, limitations, official handoff	Make lineage visible in every major workflow
Accessibility	Compliance afterthought	Persistent preferences and accessible content creation across all modules	Treat WCAG 2.2 AA as a release gate
Procurement	Long custom questionnaire cycle	Ready-to-send security, privacy, accessibility, AI, implementation, and DPA packet	Build Trust Center and evidence library
Implementation	Custom project per customer	Configurable launch kit, templates, mappings, sandbox, training, pilot playbook	Productize implementation

Feature gaps to close

The following areas determine whether Semester is perceived as a real University OS or a very strong prototype:

1. Production-grade identity and tenancy

- Institutional SSO using SAML or OIDC.
- SCIM provisioning for enterprise institutions.
- Role, scope, capability, and consent enforcement on every sensitive request.
- Institution, school, department, program, cohort, and course-level configuration.

2. Source-of-truth and trust layer

- Every important fact shows its source, sync time, confidence, and limitation.
- Source states: Institution verified, Imported, Student entered, Estimated, Needs review, Stale, Unavailable.
- Official handoff pattern for registration, grades, payments, housing, financial aid, and other authoritative systems.
- Field-level lineage and reconciliation dashboard for integrations.

3. Integration maturity

- Canvas, Blackboard, Brightspace, and Moodle through standard patterns where possible.
- LTI 1.3/LTI Advantage for learning-tool interoperability.

- SIS gateway approach for Banner, Workday, Ellucian, and institution-approved systems.
- Google and Microsoft calendar/file connections with incremental consent.
- Webhook signing, idempotency, retries, dead-letter queues, sync status, and reconciliation.

4. Institution console

- Tenant onboarding wizard.
- Campus content governance.
- Integration command center.
- Feature flag and policy control.
- Role and permission simulator.
- AI policy configuration.
- Audit-log search.
- Content freshness and accessibility status.
- Aggregate, privacy-safe adoption dashboard.

5. Evidence and outcomes

- Student clarity score: “I understand what I need to do next.”
- Plan completion.
- Schedule conflicts resolved.
- Primary and backup course plan creation.
- Advisor agenda creation.
- Search-to-action completion.
- Support-resource discovery.
- Career evidence saved.
- Staff usefulness and implementation satisfaction.

Do not lead with generic capabilities such as “AI tutor,” “LMS sync,” “calendar,” or “flashcards.” Those are increasingly expected. Lead with Semester’s ability to connect **graduation path, time, money, learning, support, campus life, and career evidence** into one student-controlled system. ^[1780]_[1781]

1EdTech TrustEd Apps plan

1EdTech’s TrustEd Apps program evaluates edtech applications using member-established criteria around student-data practices and PII handling. The program includes product vetting and certification, and its directory distinguishes products that have been reviewed, vetted, or certified. ^[1686]_[1]

What “passing” requires

For Data Privacy Certification, 1EdTech reviews a supplier’s publicly available Privacy Policy and Terms of Service against its Data Privacy Rubric. It may also consider related documentation such as advertising and AI policies, and requires public documentation that supports the claims made in the vetting process. ^[1499][1501]

Do not treat TrustEd Apps as a badge you buy. Treat it as a documentation and operations program that proves what Semester actually does.

Semester TrustEd Apps workstreams

Workstream	What Semester needs	Evidence to prepare
Privacy	Clear collection, use, sharing, retention, deletion, and student-control practices	Privacy Policy, Terms, DPA, retention schedule, deletion process, subprocessor list
Student data	Student owns plans, drafts, files, sharing decisions, and approved portfolio content	Student Data Promise, data inventory, export/delete controls, consent UX screenshots
Advertising	No behavioral advertising based on education records or student activity	Advertising Policy, sponsorship-labeling rules, data-use restrictions
AI	Explain AI use, providers, data handling, opt-in/opt-out, source controls, ownership, and deletion	AI Policy, provider register, AI controls screenshots, source-grounding documentation
Security	Secure SDLC, access controls, encryption, monitoring, incident response, vendor review	Security overview, architecture diagram, access-control model, incident plan, test evidence
Accessibility	Accessibility maturity, conformance status, barriers, remediation path	Accessibility statement, VPAT or roadmap, test procedure, issue-report channel
Interoperability	Standards-based integration approach and tested implementations	LTI certification plan, integration guide, connector specifications, test evidence
Transparency	Public information that matches product behavior	Trust Center, policy changelog, status page, support contact

TrustEd Apps readiness checklist

Before starting formal vetting, publish or finalize:

- ☐ Privacy Policy
- ☐ Terms of Service
- ☐ Acceptable Use Policy
- ☐ Advertising and Sponsorship Policy
- ☐ Student Data Promise
- ☐ AI Policy
- ☐ Subprocessor Register
- ☐ Security Overview
- ☐ Data Retention and Deletion Policy
- ☐ Data Processing Addendum
- ☐ Accessibility Statement
- ☐ VPAT or formal VPAT roadmap
- ☐ Incident Response Summary
- ☐ Support and Escalation Policy

- [] Trust Center
- [] Product status page
- [] Contact channels: privacy, security, accessibility, support
- [] Data inventory and data-flow diagram
- [] Evidence of export, deletion, consent, revocation, and access controls

The 1EdTech Generative AI Data Rubric emphasizes disclosure when AI is used, opt-in or opt-out options, description of AI in privacy documentation, identification of data sources, and clarity on whether AI is internal or supplied by third parties. It also states that assessments should be completed annually. [¹⁶⁸¹]

Recommended certification sequence

1. Join or confirm appropriate 1EdTech membership.
2. Publish the Semester Trust Center and all core public policies.
3. Complete the Data Privacy Rubric self-assessment.
4. Request Data Privacy Vetting through 1EdTech.
5. Address policy or documentation concerns raised during review.
6. Complete the Generative AI Data Rubric.
7. Complete the Accessibility and Security Practices self-assessments.
8. Pursue relevant interoperability certifications once integrations are ready—especially LTI 1.3/LTI Advantage.
9. Maintain annually: update policies, processors, AI providers, architecture changes, accessibility status, and security evidence.

The accessibility and security rubrics are self-assessment tools intended to help suppliers communicate maturity to educational buyers; the accessibility rubric is specifically structured as a supplier self-review against defined criteria. [¹⁶⁸³][¹⁶⁷⁵]

Institutional trust playbook

Semester should operate a trust process before, during, and after every institutional sale.

Before the buyer meeting

Prepare an institutional **Trust Room** containing:

- Executive product overview
- Architecture diagram
- Data-flow diagram
- System boundaries and authoritative-source model
- Security overview
- Privacy and FERPA posture
- AI governance summary
- Accessibility statement and VPAT
- Subprocessor register
- DPA

Standard contract
Support SLA
Incident-response summary
Business continuity summary
Integration catalog
Implementation guide
Pilot statement of work
Pricing overview
Insurance and company documentation

During discovery

Ask institutions:

- Which student journey is most fragmented today?
- Which cohort needs the most immediate support?
- What systems are authoritative for academic, financial, identity, and learning data?
- What data may Semester receive during the pilot?
- What must stay in existing systems?
- Which offices need to publish content or actions?
- What accessibility, security, privacy, and procurement requirements apply?
- What does success look like in 90 days and in one academic year?
- Which stakeholders must approve pilot expansion?

During implementation

Use a shared implementation plan:

Week	Semester responsibility	Institution responsibility
1–2	Discovery, technical scope, success design	Sponsor, cohort, stakeholders, data boundaries
3–4	Tenant configuration, content setup, pilot environment	Branding, program data, resource owners, approval
5–6	SSO or secure login, training materials, accessibility review	IT/security participation, staff champions
7–8	Student onboarding, support setup, launch communications	Cohort invitations, advisor/faculty orientation
9–16	Monitor usage, resolve friction, collect feedback	Weekly feedback, content updates, issue escalation
17–26	Outcomes report and expansion recommendation	Renewal, expansion, or next-pilot decision

After launch

Run a quarterly institutional review:

Student clarity
Meaningful actions completed
Planning and registration readiness
Advisor usefulness

Resource discovery
Integration health
Content freshness
Accessibility findings
Support trends
Privacy and security events
Feature adoption
Expansion opportunities

Pilot RFP package

Do not pitch an undefined “full campus transformation” first. Package Semester as a concrete, low-risk, measurable pilot.

Recommended first offer

Semester Registration and Path Pilot

Purpose: Help a defined student cohort understand academic progress, prepare for registration, create a feasible term plan, resolve conflicts, save backups, and arrive at advising conversations prepared.

Recommended cohort: 25–100 students.

Recommended audiences:

- First-year students before registration.
- Transfer students.
- Students in programs with complex prerequisites.
- Advising-center students.
- Student athletes.
- One college, school, department, or academic program.

Pilot scope

Student profile and goals
Path Snapshot
Degree-requirement planning estimate
Term planning
Course search and comparison
Schedule conflict detection
Primary and backup course plans
Registration-readiness checklist
Advisor meeting agenda
Action Center
Source and freshness labels
Feedback and support workflow

Mobile and accessibility baseline
Aggregate pilot reporting

Explicit exclusions

Official registration execution
Official degree certification
Automatic add/drop/withdrawal
Deep production SIS write access
Full LMS replacement
Payment, billing, housing, dining, health, or emergency workflows
Unrestricted AI agents
Surveillance analytics
Public student social feeds

This scope is compelling because it solves a high-value problem while respecting system-of-record boundaries. Your implementation blueprint recommends the same focused Registration Path Pilot instead of attempting every University OS capability simultaneously. [1780][1781]

Pilot RFP response structure

- 1. Executive summary
- 2. Student problem and institutional opportunity
- 3. Semester platform overview
- 4. Pilot scope
- 5. Student journey and workflow diagrams
- 6. Roles and permission model
- 7. Data scope and data minimization
- 8. Security and privacy posture
- 9. Accessibility approach
- 10. AI governance and academic-integrity controls
- 11. Integration approach and official-system boundaries
- 12. Implementation plan and timeline
- 13. Training and launch communications
- 14. Support model and service levels
- 15. Success metrics and evaluation design
- 16. Pricing and pilot terms
- 17. Expansion roadmap
- 18. Appendices: DPA, security summary, policies, architecture, references

Pilot success metrics

Category	Measure
Activation	Account creation and completed onboarding
Planning	Path Snapshot viewed, term plan saved, backup course saved
Readiness	Registration checklist completion, conflict resolution
Advising	Agenda creation, student/advisor usefulness rating

Category	Measure
Clarity	“I understand what I need to do next”
Support	Search-to-resource action, support request success
Operations	Content freshness, integration health, support response
Expansion	Student retention within Semester, staff willingness to continue, next-cohort demand

Product strategy scorecard

Pricing tiers

Package	Buyer	Core value	Suggested structure
Semester Free	Individual student	Profile, goals, basic planning, one plan, simple schedule, directory, reminders	Free
Semester Plus	Individual student	Unlimited plans, comparisons, scenarios, calendar sync, sharing, export	Monthly and annual subscription
Semester Pro	Power student	Advanced scenarios, portfolio, career tools, advisor collaboration, selected AI features	Higher monthly and annual subscription
Semester Access	Institution-sponsored student	SSO, verified data, campus directory, institutional features, governed AI	Included in institutional license
Semester Registration	Department or institution	Path, planning, registration readiness, advisor agenda, rollout support	Fixed pilot + annual subscription
Semester Student Success	Institution	Action Center, advising, support discovery, campus resources	Annual license by enrollment or cohort
Semester Learning	Institution or academic unit	Course workspace, study assets, faculty controls, LTI	Annual license + implementation
Semester Enterprise	Multi-campus institution	SSO, SCIM, integrations, custom governance, enterprise support	Multi-year custom agreement

Do not paywall a student’s personal-data export, deletion, or basic access to student-owned content. Your current commercial model already follows this principle. ^[1780][1781]

Go-to-market loops

Loop	Entry point	Value moment	Conversion
Student utility loop	Free schedule builder, advisor agenda, registration checklist	Student saves a plan or resolves a conflict	Account creation, Plus/Pro, referral
Campus ambassador loop	Student leaders and creators	Peer adoption, club onboarding, event participation	Campus density and institution leads
Advisor loop	Shared agenda and student plan	Advisor has a better meeting with less reconstruction	Department pilot
Institution pilot loop	Registration or transfer cohort	Measurable clarity and readiness	Annual license and expansion

Loop	Entry point	Value moment	Conversion
Content loop	Guides, tools, webinars, student stories	Useful free resource	Lead capture and product education
Partner loop	LMS, SIS, career, tutoring, community partners	Better integrated workflow	Co-sell, referral, marketplace
Employer/alumni loop	Opt-in portfolio and skills evidence	Better student-alumni/employer connection	Career partner revenue
Community loop	Events, mentors, study groups, organizations	Belonging and useful connection	Retention and campus adoption

Viral onboarding metrics

Do not optimize only for invites. Optimize for useful, consent-based network effects.

Metric	Definition	Why it matters
Time to first value	Time from signup to first saved plan, resolved conflict, or useful action	Measures onboarding clarity
Path Snapshot rate	% of new users who reach a credible path view	Measures core-product activation
First meaningful action	% who complete a planning, study, support, career, or advising action	Better than page views
Advisor agenda rate	% who create an agenda before an advising moment	Demonstrates human-workflow value
Backup-course rate	% with ranked registration alternatives	Demonstrates readiness value
Invite acceptance rate	% of intentional study-group, mentor, or club invites accepted	Measures community quality
Group activation rate	% of invited groups that complete a useful shared action	Measures collaboration value
Referral-to-activation	Referred users who reach first meaningful action	Measures referral quality
Week-4 retention	Users returning after the novelty window	Measures recurring utility
Weekly Path Progressed Students	Students completing at least one meaningful action per week	Strongest combined habit metric
Student clarity score	"I know what I need to do next"	Core product promise
Institutional expansion rate	Pilots that add cohorts, modules, or renew	Best B2B proof point

Immediate next steps

1. Create a **Semester Trust Center** with the public policies and evidence required for TrustEd Apps readiness.
2. Build an internal **TrustEd Apps evidence matrix** mapping every rubric question to a policy, control, screenshot, owner, and review date.

3. Package the **Semester Registration and Path Pilot** as a 26-week pilot offer with scope, exclusions, implementation plan, metrics, and pricing.
4. Build an **Institution Trust Room** for RFPs and procurement.
5. Publish the **One Operating System for University Life** architecture page and interactive product map.
6. Launch free student tools that lead into Semester accounts and connected plans.
7. Recruit 10–20 students, 3–5 advisors, and one institution or department design partner.
8. Measure clarity, planning, registration readiness, advisor usefulness, and support discovery before making outcome claims.
9. Pursue 1EdTech Data Privacy Vetting first, then AI, accessibility, security, and interoperability readiness in sequence.
10. Use every pilot to build a real case study, implementation template, security answer library, and expansion playbook.

Semester becomes irresistible when a student sees immediate personal value, an advisor sees better-prepared conversations, an institution sees controlled implementation and trustworthy governance, and procurement sees evidence instead of promises.



1. <https://site.imsglobal.org/certifications>
2. <https://www.imsglobal.org/article/1edtech-consortium-announces-app-vetting-and-privacy-alliance>
3. <https://www.1edtech.org/workstream/vetting>
4. <https://www.1edtech.org/standards/data-privacy/rubric>
5. <https://www.1edtech.org/standards/accessibility-rubric>
6. <https://www.1edtech.org/program/trustedapps>
7. <https://www.1edtech.org/standards/data-privacy>
8. <https://www.1edtech.org/standards/security-practices-rubric>
9. <https://www.1edtech.org/1edtech-trusted-apps-alliance>
10. <https://www.1edtech.org/certification/data-privacy>
11. <https://www.1edtech.org/certification/data-privacy/faq>
12. <https://www.imsglobal.org/spec/dataprivacy/accessibility/v1p0>
13. <https://www.1edtech.org/standards/ai-rubric>
14. <https://www.1edtech.org/1edtech-article/new-1edtech-rubrics-provide-valuable-insights-for-educators-selecting-trusted>
15. <https://www.1edtech.org/article/1edtech-consortium-launches-trusted-apps-program-institutions-and-edtech-suppliers>
16. Semester_Unified_Platform_Execution_Blueprint.docx
17. Semester-Master-Implementation-Brief-v2-2.pdf

